

Tony Perman*

Musical meaning and indexicality in the analysis of ceremonial mbira music

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Abstract: In this essay I examine three different indexical processes that inform meaning during a mbira performance in Zimbabwe in order to clarify the nature of meaning in musical practice. I continue others' efforts to provincialize language and correct the damage done by "symbolocentrism's" continued reliance on post-Saussurian models of signification and structure by addressing processes of purpose, effect, and agency in meaning. Emphases on language and/or structure mislead explanations of musical meaning and compromise the understanding of meaning itself. By foregrounding the unique properties of indexicality in musical practice, and highlighting three distinct indexical processes that drive music's meaning (deictic, metonym, and replica), I help free meaning from language and offer an ethnomusicological counterpoint to multidisciplinary efforts that define meaning within linguistic and physiological paradigms. Indexical meaning is direct but unpredictable, rooted in experience, embodied habits, and the here and now.

Keywords: index, meaning, music, semiotics, Zimbabwe

Broadly speaking, this essay is about musical meaning. More narrowly, it examines the nature of indices as defined by C. S. Peirce and their primary importance to musical inquiry relative to the limited relevance of his concept of symbols. More narrowly still, I ask whether one specific performance of the mbira piece "Shumba" at one particular ceremony in Zimbabwe can be explained via symbolism, or is more appropriately understood through different indexical processes. Despite flourishing in seemingly every community on earth for millennia and despite decades of thorough multidisciplinary attention, explanations for why musicking feels good and what it means remain elusive and fragmented for musicians, scholars, and critics.¹ Music's power is knowable, but seemingly unexplainable. Words fail.

¹ In Gary Tomlinson's audacious recent work *A Million Years of Music*, he says that "Music stands before the human, both chronologically and in the sense of a coeval challenging of human exceptionalism (Tomlinson 2016: 150; see also Tomlinson 2015).

*Corresponding author: Tony Perman, Grinnell College, Grinnell, IA, USA, E-mail: permanan@grinnell.edu

Symbols only emerge in narrow instances that rarely involve music without language.² Inspired by Dipesh Chakrabarty and Eduardo Kohn (Chakrabarty 2000; Kohn 2013), who provincialize Europe and language respectively, I provincialize symbols, confining them to their corner of the analytic landscape to continue flourishing in demonstrations of interpretive insight without infecting meaningful processes that have little to do with them. Modifying Nietzsche's claim about truth, symbols "are illusions which we have forgotten are illusions" (Nietzsche 1873). Musical inquiry is ill-served by analyses reliant on Saussure's sign, Peirce's symbol, or linguistic analogies. To move people, shape experience, or feel true, indexicality is essential. Indexicality's importance has been heralded before, but it seems in continual need of reminder. Music, as more than sound and the significations agreed upon a priori, is an especially apt mode through which to demonstrate the value of indexicality. However defined, meaningful musicking is an embodied and affective mode of experience. Musical practices harness the indexical presence of here and now better than other modes of expressive representation, moving beyond the vague generality of icons but never reaching the predictable generality of symbols. They are more powerful because of it.

Meaning is not the exclusive domain of language, nor is language the sole means of representation. This may be obvious, but is important to reassert. Ethnomusicologists are *still* coming to terms with the relationship of music and language. I join others in correcting the damage done by what Tomlinson calls "symbolocentrism" (2015) and its reliance on post-Saussurian models of signification and structure by addressing processes of purpose, effect, and transformation (Feld 1984; Seeger 1977; Tolbert 2001; Turino 1999, 2014). By foregrounding the properties of three distinct indexical processes, I untether meaning from language and offer an ethnomusicological counterpoint to linguistic and physiological explanations of meaning and affect.

1 Semiotic meaning

Meaning is defined in multiple ways in the literature, but *semiotic* meaning and analysis can accommodate them all. The role of the term "meaning" as a symbol in English masks some conceptual differences it has from terms in other languages. Meaning has come to mean many things and *kureva*, the most common ChiShona translation, only covers a few of these alternatives. On the one hand, its use value could appear diminished as scholars disagree on which meaning of meaning to

² See Turino's work on semiotics for the strongest ethnomusicological critique of symbolocentrism (Turino 1999, 2008, 2014).

use. On the other hand, pedantic demands for definitional precision like this one can obscure meaning's useful flexibility. As the neuro-anthropologist Terrence Deacon complains, it is striking that people are more familiar with meaning than something like a hemoglobin, "but the scientific account of concepts like function and meaning essentially lag centuries behind the sciences of these more tangible phenomena" (Deacon 2012b: 9).

When summarizing approaches to musical meaning, Timothy Rice lists four distinct definitions: signification, value, intention, and interpretation (Rice 2001). Thomas Turino, advocating for and employing Peircean theory in ethnomusicology, limits meaning to semiotic interpretants, or effects (Turino 2008, 2014). Conversely, in Kohn's anthropological applications of Peirce, he expands on Rice's unrelated list and provides no fewer than seven definitions: means-ends relations, strivings, purposes, telos, intentions, functions, significance (Kohn 2013: 72). Peirce uses meaning to refer to the character a sign attributes to its object (EP 2: 304).

I hesitate to add yet another voice to the chorus of critics lambasting innocent Saussure (Engelke 2007; Kockelman 2013; Turino 1999, 2014). Peirceans like myself are especially quick to critique Saussure, despite the obvious contributions that have emerged from his distinctions. But Saussure's sign, even if it is not of primary importance within his own system (Silverstein 2016), has unwittingly undermined decades of scholarship on meaning. The similarities between Peircean symbols and Saussurian signs lead to frequent elisions of the two systems and an undue imposition of the structuralism that emerged from Saussure's semiology on applications of Peirce's own contribution. Untethered from consequences (and interpretants) and embedded within systems and structures untroubled by individual agency, the lingering thread of Saussure's sign can be followed from Saussure himself through Levi-Strauss and his structuralist adherents to poststructuralists like Foucault and Derrida who sought to partially undo that very influence. Even animists and perspectivists enacting the ontological turn emerge from structuralism's legacy (Descola 2016; Turner 2009). As Turner points out, the fact that poststructuralists and anti-structuralists have somehow retained key elements of Levi-Strauss's synthetic approach demonstrates the "hold" structuralism acquired in the French cultural imagination and social theory (Turner 2009: 8).

One such "hold" is the grip language has held on analysis. Saussure was a linguist, so it is unsurprising that his sign was intended to demonstrate something about language. But while Saussure embeds language within the broader category of semiology, Barthes and Levi-Strauss invert it (Barthes 1964; Levi-Strauss 1963), rendering language as the model and guide of all meaning-making. Once Levi-Strauss took this linguistic approach to myth, kinship, and "structure" (Descola 2016: 35), its legacy was assured. Language, or discourse, became the primary

evidence for whatever truth was being examined. Structuralism's reach has ensured that meaning itself has become that which is most easily understood through the language of discourse and Saussure's structured sign.³ It is worth asking whether replacing Saussure's narrow, linguocentric sign with Peirce's in the structuralist family tree could allow for agency and experience to find their way into the picture. Instead of focusing one's attention solely upon the relations between signs and the objects they represent, one could also focus on the relations between signs and the effects they have upon the ones who interpret them . . . and then the relations between these two relations (Kockelman 2011). Thus putting *parole* back into *langue*, so to speak.

Signs reveal and reflect processes of meaning-making; they are not static. Indexical meaning, in particular, is direct but unpredictable, rooted in experience, embodied habits, and the here and now. By highlighting indexicality, I defend a semiotic ethnomusicology against complaints that it is mechanistic, taxonomic, atomistic, or structural. For instance, Ruth Stone argues that "semiotics has emphasized product to some exclusion of process" (Stone 2008: 84). Rice's preference to "focus on categorizing processes of interpretation rather than sign types, as is often done in semiotics" (Rice 2001: 30), is a worthy one, but his distinction is more reflective of structuralist interpretations of semiotic tools than it is of their merits. What is a sign type in Peirce if not a way to categorize processes of interpretation?

Martin Clayton points out that the main problem emerges when semiotic approaches rely on language rather than a potential "phonocentrism" promised by music scholarship. Equating semiotics with linguistic approaches, he wants to "redress a balance that has tilted overwhelmingly towards semiotic approaches and away from more phenomenological, experiential, and/or non-symbolic studies" (Clayton 2001: 9), and he critiques that problematic link of meaning to structure and semiosis (2001: 14). Harris Berger suggests that his phenomenological approach would help "us to understand the meaning of a work or performance, not just as the sum of its semiotic parts – or even as a whole that is greater than the sum of its semiotic parts – but as the result of a person's differentiated yet holistic engagement with those many parts" (Berger 2009: 35).

3 Different disciplines have responded to structuralism's reliance on language to illuminate meaning and culture in different ways. Semiotically-inclined linguistic anthropologists increasingly suggest that the properties unique to language are an ineffective basis for understanding culture, as is implied by structuralism (Nakassis 2018: 285). Affect theorists, recognizing the limitations of Saussure, the structuralism he inspired, and the poststructuralism that followed, have discarded meaning entirely in their effort to undo the structuralist legacy (Hemmings 2005; Leys 2011; Tomlinson 2016), throwing the baby out with the bathwater.

While the phenomenology each recommends and the semiotics each condemns are not focused on Peirce, his system of semiotics is damned by association to the post-Saussurian structural semiology that led to each of these turns away from the semiotic. Structuralism often ignores experience (and agency), hence the attraction of phenomenology for scholars like Berger and Clayton. But Peirce's semiotic is grounded in a project similarly attentive to experience that he has called both phenomenology and phaneroscopy. He unites experiential phenomena and the significant in consistent, productive ways long before Bourdieu and others tried to synthesize the "objectivity" of structuralism with the "subjectivity" of phenomenology. For Peirce, signs are dynamic and phenomenological processes of relation and representation, not taxonomies of products and parts. Peircean semiotics is better understood within this phenomenology than in opposition to it. Recalling Berger's argument, "semiotic parts" necessarily includes the interpreter's "engagement with those many parts."

Efforts to detach affect, embodiment, and experience itself from a reliance on language (and symbols) have separated the body from meaning itself, doubling down on the previously implicit binary between language and the body. Meaning, now severed from that which makes one most alive, is rendered inert, dead. Hence Hemmings's suggestion that Brian Massumi approaches affect in order to escape the "pernicious reign of signification" (Hemmings 2005: 554). Despite unending arguments against a Cartesian split of mind and body, language, meaning, culture, and social construction oppose the body, innateness, nature, and universality all over again. The important turn away from linguocentrism and accompanying moves to bring the body back to the humanities included troubling dimensions that rejected the value of meaning because of its equation with language in the reductive intellectual legacy of Saussure.

2 Signs

Among the many attempts Peirce made to define the sign in his career, perhaps the most precise is one he offered in his essay "Pragmatism" in 1907; "A sign is anything . . . which mediates between an object and an interpretant; since it is both determined by the object *relatively to the interpretant*, and determines the interpretant *in reference to the object*, in such wise as to cause the interpretant to be determined by the object through the mediation of this 'sign'" (EP 2: 409–410). To paraphrase, a sign is anything that has an effect in an interpreter based on its representation of something else.

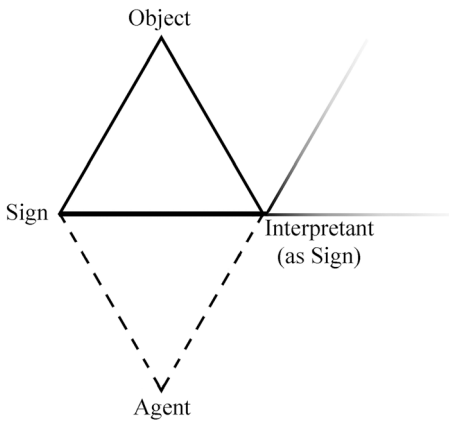


Figure 1: Basic sign of C. S. Peirce (based on Kockelman 2011: 714).⁴

Peirce's sign thus has three requisite parts: object or signified, sign or signifier, and interpretant or effect see Figure 1. This third component, the interpretant, is famously absent from Saussure's semiology. An agent to interpret is necessary as well, but not technically part of the sign.

Each component is essential; none is privileged. Objects lead to signs, which represent them; signs leads to interpretants, which are the effects of those representations. Each element is a requisite component. Change one and you change the sign as a whole. Prioritizing the object signified reduces the sign to Saussure's semiological signifier (1966), which pays little attention to the effects of signs (Peirce's interpretants). Prioritizing the interpretant relegates the sign to Derrida's sense of play (1978), with little regard for reality. Accepting the interpretant requires acknowledging that the effect a sign has is as important to semiosis as the vehicle of representation and is not a foregone conclusion. Accepting objects as informing the signs that represent them means accepting that there is a reality for the interpreter that guides that interpretation. The fact that any omissions recall the legacy of structuralism and poststructuralism exposes just how incompatible Peirce's approach to signs is with Saussure and his intellectual descendants, including Barthes and Derrida. While the differences are extensive, the key distinctions of Peirce's system are reflected in the index and the interpretant.

⁴ My dotted line reflects the limited definition of agency I use relative to Kockelman. An agent is capable of selecting and instigating (Kockelman 2017: 27). Kockelman argues that they are also capable of being selected, a requirement to which I pay little attention. I tie agency to the capacity and the freedom to fulfill the ends that one desires, to act knowingly (Lambek 2016: 49). Thus I would not attribute agency to bacteria or lawnmowers, for instance (see Kockelman 2017; Mahmood 2005; Tomlinson 2016).

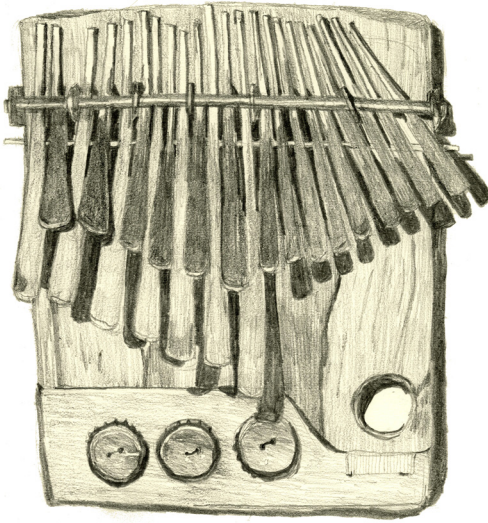


Figure 2: Drawing of a mbira
(courtesy of Anne Rogers).

2.1 Trichotomy of the sign-object relationship: Icons, indices, and symbols

Peirce seems to subdivide almost endlessly,⁵ but there are three basic sign-object relations: icon, index, and symbol.

For many of you, this drawing is likely an icon of a mbira; it is a sign of resemblance.⁶ It can't be authentic; it can't be true; its characters simply resemble those of the signified object. If you have never seen a mbira, this likely resembles something else entirely.

An index is a sign of contiguity, connected to its object through co-occurrence or cause and effect. My finger as I point to it is an index of the drawing. The label of Figure 2 above is also an index of the drawing, one which likely shaped your interpretation of it as an icon. In saying "*that* mbira," the demonstrative pronoun is an index of the *word* mbira and the instrument to which it draws attention.

⁵ While Peirce's most famous subdivisions (based on trichotomies of the sign, the sign-object relation, and the sign-interpretant relation) leads to 10 classes of sign, at other times he adds further nuance and sets of distinctions to produce up to 66 different sign classes. Because the 10 trichotomies he outlines are informed by the nested qualities of firstness, secondness, and thirdness, they lead to a "mere" 66 instead of the mathematically possible 59,049 (EP 2: 480)!

⁶ For the artist, if working from direct observation of a specific instrument, it may operate as a dicent index. No icon or index will predictably refer to the same object via the same manner of representation for everyone. To know for sure, one would have to ask.

A symbol is a sign of stipulation (Cumming 2000: 93), representing its object through a law of interpretation (Short 2007: 221). “mbira” is a symbol for a specific musical instrument, a lamellophone from the Shona community in Zimbabwe used primarily during ancestral spirit possession ceremonies. Every utterance of mbira in this presentation is a replica of that general sign. Once you know what it means, you should hopefully respond accordingly.

A consensus definition of symbol remains elusive and Peirce himself defined it in at least 10 different ways over the course of his career. My definition is based on three scholars of Peirce unconvinced that convention is a sufficient criteria: Turino, Short, and Naomi Cumming (Cumming 2000; Short 2007; Turino 2014). Turino defines symbols according to “linguistic definition” that must be agreed upon; both the sign and object must be general (Turino 2014: 197–198). Similarly, Naomi Cumming defines the symbol as “a stipulated sign” (Cumming 2000: 93) and Short describes the symbol as “a sign of that object that is assigned to it by a rule of interpretation” (Short 2007: 221). Symbolic sign-object relations should reflect a different form of connection than resemblance and contiguity. They work because their objects are predetermined, predictable, and fixed. Defining symbols as arbitrary, general, conventional, or systemic is inadequate (see also Deacon 2012a: 11). Symbols play little role in the success of Shumba at the ceremony described here. Of course, they help shape the spiritual, musical, and familial context of performance, but they have little impact on whether this particular performance will be successful or not. Thus three kinds of sign-object relations – icon, index, and symbol – reflecting three ways in which a sign can be understood to represent its object – resemblance, contiguity, and stipulation.⁷

2.2 A word about symbols and language

Celebrations of indexicality such as this one can often imply an equation between Peircean symbols and language itself, especially since the Saussurian sign that receives much of the critique, and to which Peirce’s symbol is most often compared, is explicitly a linguistic sign. The vague ubiquity of the word symbol in everyday English also clouds attempts at theoretical precision.⁸ Inaccurate

⁷ This is perhaps the simplest set of distinctions possible within Peircean semiotics, attending exclusively to the sign-object relationship. Further distinctions are possible, based on firstness, secondness, and thirdness, to the sign itself, the sign’s relationship to the interpretant, the object itself, the interpretant, the dynamic interpretant, and so on (Peirce 1998; Turino 1999, 2014; Perman 2020).

⁸ Turino advocates using P-symbol as an explicitly Peircean version, in order to avoid confusion between the colloquial symbol and Peirce’s symbol (Turino 2014).

equations with social convention loom over explanations of symbols, casting shadows that obscure their utility and distinction.

While it might appear as if all words are symbols and all symbols are words, this is incorrect. Language relies on both indices and symbols.⁹ Pronouns are indices, for example. In his groundbreaking work on metapragmatics in language, Silverstein points out that any linguistic fact is “necessarily an indexical fact” (Silverstein 2003: 194–5). His work shows not only how important indexicality is to language, but how layers of indexicality can generate profound precision via linguistic reference. Keeping in mind that symbols are general signs for general objects exposes just how important other sign types (such as the index) are for precision in language.

At the other end of the specificity spectrum, art, music, and pornography are famously difficult to define and can’t really operate effectively as symbols because their definitions are in the eyes and ears of their beholders, revealing indexical understandings rather than general, stipulated ones. Interpreting anything symbolically depends on understanding it indexically as well.

Things that are assigned a rule of interpretation, like a national flag, can operate as symbols even if no words accompany their presence.¹⁰ Seven in a way, Saussure already provincialized language (and symbols), but his followers have not always heeded his example. Analytically, it is more effective to focus on the ways signs represent objects and have effects rather than the modes through which they do so. Whether a linguistic or musical sign operates indexically or symbolically can reveal more about the way that sign is meaningful than whether it is a linguistic or musical sign.

An emphasis on music and indices might also imply that language and symbols don’t matter to ceremonial life in Zimbabwe. Of course, this is not true. Language permeates proceedings via conversation, directives about ritual action, and lyrics sung. Obviously, each of these frames included symbols, but the fact that those lyrics must be sung (and accompanied by *hosho*), and that those conversations are only possible after the fact, suggest that it is the indexicality of ceremonial experience that is of central significance. My intent is not to erase the importance of language or symbols, but to foreground the importance of music and indices.

⁹ Attention to the role of indexicality in “language” has become a defining feature for linguistics and linguistic anthropology as it moves beyond its structuralist heritage (Nakassis 2016).

¹⁰ Again, as with the drawing of the mbira, whether this operates symbolically or not would depend on who is interpreting it and how they learned to connect it to its object.

3 “Shumba”

The ceremony was held in a farmhouse near Harare that had been resettled recently during Zimbabwe’s fast-track land reform. Having profited from the farm’s occupation and resettlement, a Member of Parliament in the ruling Zimbabwe African National Union – Patriotic Front (ZANU-PF) party now lived in the main house and was selling cheap plots of land parceled from the estate to prospective farmers with good government connections. I accompanied one of those prospective farmers hoping to buy land for far cheaper than would have otherwise been possible. We arrived late so a room full of women, including the entrepreneurial MP, was already in attendance. They were waiting for us since we were arriving with the only mbira player; I’ll call him Oga.

Shona spirit possession ceremonies, called *mapira* (sing. *bira*) should ideally include more than one mbira player accompanied by *hosho* gourd rattles. The purpose is for ancestral spirits, called *vadzimu* (sing. *mudzimu*), to possess their mediums via collective musicking and dancing. Two is a minimum and three to

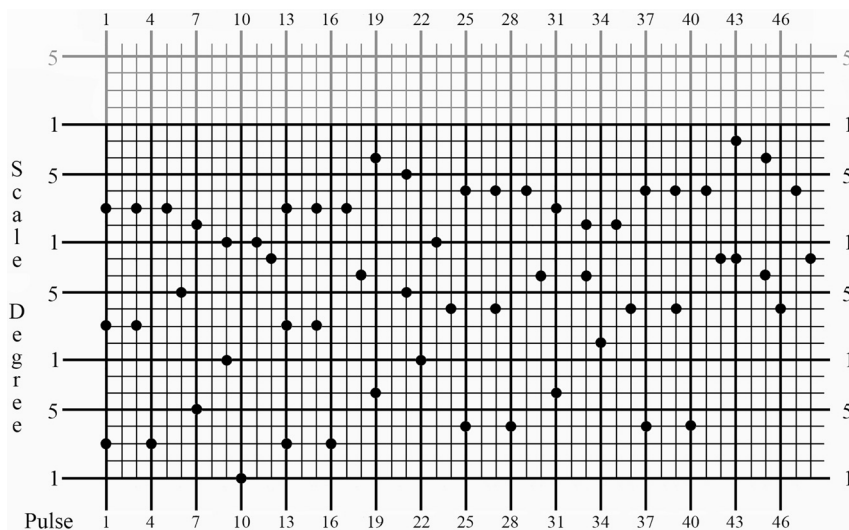


Figure 3: Shumba.¹²

¹² This method of notating mbira pieces was developed by Klaus-Peter Brenner for his book *Chipendani und mbira* (1997). It has the advantage of deemphasizing any particular tuning system and the reading tendencies informed by Western notation. Kofi Agawu (1995), among others, argues in favor of using western notation, and I do use it elsewhere, but Brenner’s system is ideal in visualizing the patterns that define mbira music without implying any specific time signature or sense of duration.

five is certainly common. The music itself is defined by two interlocking parts that demand multiple players: *kushaura* (to lead) and *kutsinhira* (to follow). For reasons that were never fully explained, the other mbira players never showed up, leaving Oga with more than he bargained for. One person can play alone if necessary, but it works best if he or she is a master musician. Legendary performers like Bandambira Mubaiwa, Tute Chigamba, and Sekuru Gora are famous for their ability to combine the two mbira parts and carry a ceremony on their own, doubling bass notes, filling in descending lines with a quick index finger, and directing their virtuosity to the needs of the ceremony. Oga was not one of these legendary musicians. He was competent, to be sure, but nothing more. His prior experience playing during *mapira* ceremonies to this point was primarily supporting the *kushaura* parts as other more experienced players made the musical decisions. He was now solely responsible for providing music essential to a ceremony among strangers on occupied land for a serving member of parliament in the ruling party. Somewhat randomly, but knowing it was a piece he could play for a long time, he played “Shumba,” one of the oldest and most important ceremonial mbira pieces. Before long, Oga’s mbira playing was overwhelmed by *hosho* (gourd shakers) playing, clapping hands, dancing feet, singing, and shouting. A typical ceremony in many ways, it was a multi-sensory, multi-modal affair. But the mbira made it possible. Our hosts waited until Oga had arrived, for a ceremony seemed impossible with the mbira to drive it. He played for hours.

“Shumba” means lion, but in the context of mbira it can also refer to the important territorial lion spirits called *mhondoro* (Lan 1985). Tute Chigamba says people call it “Shumba” because you have to be careful in the wilderness. Lions are dangerous, after all. He says, “In modern life we have cars. Those are the lions now.” It is a song fit for ageless spirits, devoted mediums, and the urban crowd we found ourselves in that day near Harare.

The basic progression of dyads for Shumba is C E A C F A D F B D E G (Grupe 2004: 206).¹¹ Numerically, the roots can be rendered as 3 5 1 3 6 1 4 6 2 4 5 7, as shown in Figure 3. These roots reflect a common style of mbira playing in which the bass notes of the *kushaura* fall directly on the beat. This is how Oga played throughout the ceremony, but without the *kutsinhira* part, which for “Shumba” is typically an exact, or very similar, repetition of the *kushaura*. It provides bass notes that “echo” the *kushaura* notes and fall on the second pulse directly after each beat. Other examples of this *kutsinhira* technique include “Dande,” “Chipindura,” “Muzorewa,” “Kuzanga,” “Shumba yaNgwasha,” among others. Sonically, the bass notes are heard as doubled throughout, as shown in Figure 4.

11 See Berliner (1993), Brenner (1997), Grupe (2004), and Scherzinger (2013) for more in-depth analysis of mbira harmonic relationships.



Figure 5: Key passage from Shumba in multiple mbira tunings.

identifiable as “Shumba” and equally capable of eliciting communal participation and spirit possession.

Oga began to play. The room was crowded awkwardly as mediums and musicians accustomed to the benches and mud walls of rural ceremonial spaces were seated on sofas and rugs. Oga’s timid opening notes were joined enthusiastically by a woman playing the *hosho* (ground rattles) next to him, the prospective farmer hoping to acquire land that day. Although not an mbira player or a medium, she was the most accomplished musician in the room and led the singing, dancing, and *hosho* playing. Within a minute or two, women were singing, feeling out dance steps, and getting into the collective groove.

Semiotically, several things happened when Oga began. The initial sounds that reached our ears sounded like mbira music; timbres, melodies, and attacks resembling those from past encounters with the instrument. This iconicity led quickly to form and genre recognition, one of the key functions of musical iconicity (Turino 2014: 193). The type “mbira music” is a common component of the Shona bira ceremony.¹³ Oga’s successful representation of that type, which

¹³ Not all bira ceremonies use the mbira. Drumming is perhaps even more common, although the connection between the mbira and the bira is a strong indexical connection for those communities in which the mbira is prevalent.

most everyone anticipated, confirmed expectations and allowed people to attend to the instance in an informed way. The differences between this performance and previous ones are initially ignored, as Kohn argues is essential when interpreting icons (2013: 31), and the iconicity between this performance and previous ones takes over. To attendees, proceedings seemed familiar. I recognized the form. This recognition became a new sign in the semiotic chain almost immediately.

But sonically and iconically, we're still in the realm of the possible. These similarities don't mean much yet; sounding *like* "Shumba" is not enough. The women danced joyfully, but that is only a step in the right direction. The primary purpose of this performance is to facilitate spirit possession and Oga's choice to play Shumba instead of any of the dozens of other mbira pieces he knew was almost arbitrary, based on the pragmatic understanding that he could play it correctly for as long as necessary. I have heard and played Shumba in countless versions iconic to this one on concerts stages, in classrooms, and parties, and at the level of the iconic, these performances were all basically the same. But iconicity is insufficient for possession (Perman 2020). Iconicity can spur the imagination and generate familiarity (see Turino's list of iconic functions in Turino 2014), but is incapable of representing reality, generating authenticity, or exposing truth. The goal is not to resemble an idea, but to change things, to arouse spirits and invigorate social relationships. The purpose is transformation in real time.

4 Processes of indexicality

Collectively transforming icons of possibility into indices of actuality requires skill, precision, focus, and shared purpose. Differences ignored during recognition of iconicity soon become noticed and evaluated. What works in a concert or a classroom can be quite different from what works in a ceremony because the purposes and effects themselves are often dramatically different. What is significant about *this* sign at *this* moment? Indexicality is defined by contiguity, it directs attention, and is necessarily tied to the here and now. Distinguishing between different kinds of indexical sign-object relations can help clarify the means through which signs are transformed from icons of the possible to indices of the actual. Three kinds of nested index can transform experiences in the moment and shape one's understanding of reality: deixis, metonym, and replica index. One directs attention, one recalls complex associations rooted in the past, and one brings habit and purpose together. None require symbols but each emerges from the iconicity just described.

Peirce himself distinguished between three nested kinds of iconic representation, but he paid surprisingly little attention to indexical variety. He identifies

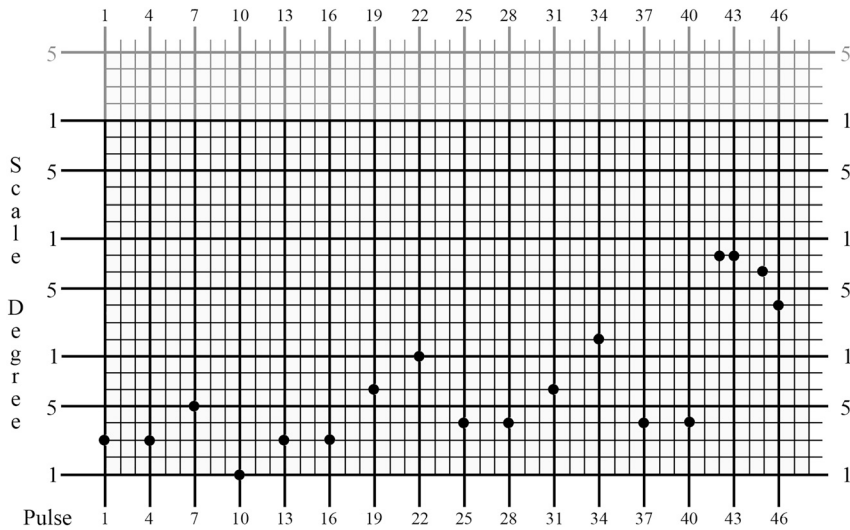


Figure 6: Bass notes for the kushaura on Shumba.

three kinds of icons in which images represent qualities, diagrams represent relations, and metaphors represent parallelism in something else (EP 2: 274). As with other Peircean trichotomies, image, diagram, and metaphor are nested reflections of the fundamental categories of firstness, secondness, and thirdness. The value in his nested icons suggests that it is worth drawing similar distinctions in indexicality. The three indices I present here are similarly nested within firstness, secondness, and thirdness: deixis, metonym, and replica index. Peirce's only distinction was between genuine and degenerate indices. Genuine indices refer to signs in existential relation to their objects, as with deixis. Degenerate indices refer to secondness as reference only (EP 2: 274), as with metonyms and replica indices.

4.1 Deixis

Deixis is pointing. All indexical signs are deictic. Peirce's genuine indices are solely deictic. Effective pointing directs attention and even predicts what comes next. In Oga's playing, the mbira's bass notes that resembled past iterations of the lead Shumba part pointed to the beat.

As the mbira's bass notes shown in Figure 6 said, "now, now, now," the *hosho* (rattles) joined in, drew people's attention, and triggered participation. Deixis draws attention to the immediate present, the here and now. This sense of "hereness" and "nowness" is the essential foundation for trance, flow,

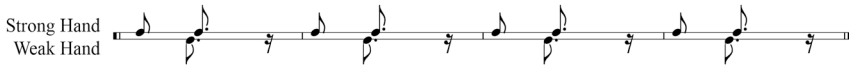


Figure 7: *Hosho* pattern reinforcing second pulse of each beat (based on Kyker 2019).

participation, *communitas*, and the possession that defines ceremonial success.¹⁴ Even the past acquires a sense of immediacy when the dead possess the living and become authentic, unquestioned facts. Inspired by Dons Scotus, and as a particular form of “thisness,” Peirce and Short refer to this indexical sense of hereness and nowness as “haecceity” (Peirce 1931–1966: 8.266; Short 2007: 50). By definition, haecceity is the absence of generality, thus the experiential absence of iconicity and symbolism. Habits inform one’s interpretation of the moment, but generality has nothing to do with the experience of hereness and nowness itself. Haecceity actualizes the possibilities of music and spirit as instances in the here and now (Short 2007: 78).¹⁵ It makes the uninterrupted contiguity of signs with here and now the foundation of experience itself, hence the potential generation of trance and flow.

At the farm, attention soon focused on the haecceity of our collective performance, absorbed in the immediate and extended present in a shared space of participatory flow. Once the *hosho* began, dancers’ and singers’ followed suit, completing a participatory texture familiar to experienced participants. Given how mbira pieces like Shumba are organized, the *hosho* pattern indexes the beat in much the same way the *kutsinhira* does.

While the *hosho* reinforces the beat, it also directs attention towards the second pulse, just as the *kutsinhira* does for most mbira pieces, including “Shumba.”¹⁶ Kyker argues that the off-beat articulation in the *hosho* is central to producing the kind of musical energy (Kyker 2019) that drives and defines good mbira music. The weak hand anticipates the second pulse slightly (hence the off-center transcription in Figure 7), which drives the energy of the ensemble, directs attention to both the second pulse and rhythmic precision, and prevents the music from sounding like a static, repetitive triplet. The iconicity between the *hosho* and the typical *kutsinhira*

¹⁴ I explain the importance of haecceity to ceremonial efficacy in greater detail in my book (Perman 2020: 134–136).

¹⁵ It can be easier to think of haecceity as an “indexical now,” but there are two species of indexical now that makes such a designation somewhat ambiguous. Turino defines one indexical now as, “dramatic pointing indices that . . . produce heightened attention to the object” (Turino 2014: 214). Surprise is an example of this. This has a very different effect to the haecceity described here, but each is rooted in the indexical deixis of now.

¹⁶ Kyker’s thorough article on the *hosho* is the inspiration for the notation provided here. She lists “Mahororo,” “Nhemamusasa,” and “Nhemamusasa yepasi” as among the few pieces whose *kutsinhira* parts emphasize the beat rather than the second pulse (Kyker 2019).

for Shumba complemented the lead kushaura played by Oga and helped minimize the absence of the *kutsinhira* follow part as he played alone. The challenge musically is to focus attention to the now and stay in the moment until the purpose of the event has been realized, whether spirit possession or participation. The resemblance of this with past events and iterations of Shumba moves into the background; attention has shifted and people are in the present.

When the *hosho* took over, Oga's playing tightened up and more effectively pointed to the here and now. The pace accelerated and everyone audibly and visibly worked harder. The singing eventually grew so loud that it is questionable whether the mbira was even audible to anyone further than a few feet away. The *hosho* drove proceedings with its deixis of now. The predictable repetition inherent in the style, combined with the tension produced by the subtle anticipation of the second pulse in the *hosho*, to sustain the attention to the here and now needed for the kinds of experiences that lead to trance and *communitas*; the sound's haecceity points to a continuously emerging present.

4.2 Metonym

But haecceity is not enough to ensure possession. A second kind of indexical process, metonymy, brings previously generated indexical associations between medium and ancestor, spirit and sound, together. For Peirce, this would be a degenerate index since the object is not in existential relation to the sign, but is simply referenced (EP 2: 274). Because of this, metonymy depends on context, habits, and memory, drawing on past deictic instances of contiguity that inform present interpretations of metonymy. Time, memory, and habit release the sign from the proximity of its object, but context and habit also ensure that the sign is interpreted as indexical. Each of the objects that mediums use to generate an icon of the ancestral *mudzimu* spirit is a metonym of that spirit. The clothing worn, the snuff consumed, even the mbira played, are indexically associated with *vadzimu* (pl. of *mudzimu*) and their ceremonies as attributes of those spirits because of a previously established existential contiguity in previous ceremonial experiences. As these associations are repeated and confirmed over time, the recognition of the object represented, the spirit, becomes habitual, even conventional.

At the farm, Oga's red shirt was a problematic index, associated with bad, unwelcome spirits. At the demand of his hosts, he played shirtless throughout. The mediums' experience, and the spirits they invited, is what mattered. As they danced with increasing abandon, their ancient spirits threw off their own shirts, a few donned feathered headdresses tied to spirits through long histories of appearance, and their words reflected the old Shona spoken by ancient spirits.

Metonymy requires the capacity to learn from past experience to connect distinct perceptions – smoke and fire, in the famous example, or a moving shadow on the ground and a flying predator overhead. Through this learning, remembered connections can be applied to present circumstance. This results in a matching of present and past association, even where the present perception is incomplete: smoke or shadow alone. This matching is as a whole iconic (the form, present shadow + its learned association, is an icon of past experience) and thus reveals the dependence of a semiosis involving learning on a prior iconicity. In effect, learning enables some species to kick iconic perception onto a higher level, yielding indexical association. Indexicality is iconicity transcended and transformed (Tomlinson 2015: 190–191).

Although Deacon requires immediate contiguity for a sign to be interpreted as an index (Deacon 2012a: 21), I do not make the same demands. This would deny Peirce's degenerate index and define all signs reliant on memory as symbols, thus negating indices of possibility, of ideas, or of memory. Ironically, Deacon goes to considerable lengths to point out the centrality of the non-intrinsic (i. e., meaning, purpose, reference, etc.) to phenomena; a characteristic he defines as "ententional." This is the foundational principle of his book *Incomplete Nature* (2012a). With metonyms, past experience and remembered associations allow a sign to index an object that is not physically present. Degenerate indices are ententional indices. The lack of proximity does not negate causality. Ceremonial mbira performance is indexical of spirits even before the spirits are there. They point the way, so to speak. Even without proximity, the deixis predicts their potential arrival as a possibility because of this metonymic connection. The potential of an awakening spirit is not to be taken lightly, nor is it a general, abstract quality. The specificity of the visiting spirits is what makes the signs that signify them so productive.

Similarly, a medium's grunt points to the possibility of possession, based on a learned association of the sound and the awakening spirit, indexically predicting the arrival of that which is not yet present, the spirit. Grunts, in general, can be associated with possessing spirits, in general, but lack the "law of interpretation" that defines symbols. This object is not stipulated, but associated by past experience. It communicates something to participants because the grunt is interpreted as a metonym of the act of possession and is eventually taken as being caused by the awakening spirit when pointing to the here and now as deixis. Processes of semiosis can include a sequence of steps between a sign and its object, thus rigid contiguity need not be the determining factor for indexicality as Deacon demands. If the performance signs don't eventually awaken spirits and lead to their visceral presence as agents, then the ceremony has failed.

4.3 Replica index

The relation of a specific instance, or token, to a general type leads to the third kind of indexical relationship, the replica index. In Peirce's First Trichotomy (of the sign itself), qualia, or "qualisigns" are manifest in instances called "sinsigns" of general types, "legisigns" (EP 2: 291). As described earlier, the sinsign-legisign (or token-type) relationship is iconic. Sinsigns are iconic replicas of legisigns. Form recognition is based on this iconicity. But legisigns are the domain of habits, and can only be interpreted appropriately if the interpreter is habituated to do so. When a sign's deictic and metonymic attributes bring its type (its legisign) into the immediate present with the *purpose* to replicate, it becomes indexical. For Short, this purpose "presupposes the existence of the legisign replicated and is therefore indicative of that legisign" (Short 2007: 212). The legisign, as object signified, carries its own expected associations that it is often *intended* to signify.¹⁷ Replica indices have purpose (2007: 194). A first-time attendee to a bira ceremony with no experience would never reach this mode of indexicality.

At first glance, this may seem like the description of a symbol, but even when legisigns are intended to signify, the object is not necessarily assigned by a rule. This is what separates symbols from replica indexes (Short 2007: 222). Short gives the example of the word "that." It is intended to signify, and each iteration replicates the legisign, but no object is assigned, thus it does not operate symbolically (2007: 222). Because replica indices reference the specific rather than the general, they are not symbols. Pointing to purpose contributes to the eventual realization of that purpose. Resembling a ceremony leads to different results than becoming one in the here and now. While the purpose is not *solely* semiotic, the representation of the legisign is deliberate and shapes how the ceremony is experienced. Mbira players want to represent and conform to a certain genre, rendering the replica of an anticipated type. People understand what to do next through this replication. Soon the rote replication of a general sign matters less, the ceremony as type is acknowledged, that acknowledgment becomes a new sign, triggering a new effect (e. g., participation), and that initial token signifying type moves into the past.

Ensuring that signs are eventually understood indexically, as actually connected to the objects represented and bringing habits and histories into the here and

¹⁷ Short distinguishes between legisigns and legisigns (G), with the (G) representing generality. Instances of legisigns (G) are not interpreted as replica indexes because there is no intent to replicate (Short 2007: 210). Rather than append the concept of legisign with the awkward "(G)," I find the distinction Short is making more effectively made with a distinction between token/type iconicity and the replica index.

now, are necessary steps for ceremonial ritual success. Mbira performance, when connecting musicians and dancers, or mediums and spirits, anticipates the future. When playing elicits spirits and their presence is felt as real, the semiotic association of performance and spirituality is taken as true. These kinds of connections are hard to fake but also can't be assumed. Unlike symbols that reliably represent objects via rules of interpretation and collective agreement, these sound-spirit connections must be manifest in the instance indexically. When a medium dresses like her spirit, the iconicity is general and doesn't represent the actual spirit. But the act of dressing adds an index of purpose to the embodiment of mimesis. The *vadzimu*, as agents, must recognize this purpose and the co-occurrence of these real-time events with the ceremonial types being deliberately signified. In this way, iconicity between this event and past events, between mediums and the spirits being invited, transform into the indexical and are potentially felt as real and true. The here and now is what matters, the indexical now. Rote repetition won't inspire spirits. Iconicity's capacity to trigger the imagination and symbolism's unique power to generalize are not the most direct modes of semiotic experience. Over the course of the 2 h that Oga played Shumba, people's collective semiotic experiences transformed from one of iconic possibility to participatory action. Spirits possessed their mediums. Beyond simply imitating the past, this is a deliberate act of *creating* the present: this ceremony, these participants, this moment, right now.

5 Symbols

As noted above, symbols are often described in the literature with a series of basic qualifying conditions. These descriptions often reflect a symbol's indexical properties as employed rather than any symbolic definition or rule of interpretation. As such, they fall short of generating the stipulation necessary to make "symbol" a symbol.

Saussure's first principle regarding the sign is that the relationship between the signifier and the signified is arbitrary (Saussure 1966: 67), a principle that has defined passive applications of semiotics or semiology ever since. More precisely, Saussure says, "the *linguistic* sign is arbitrary [emphasis mine]" (1966: 67). While true of most symbols, it is not a necessary condition. Ironically, Saussure resists equating his own sign with the term symbol precisely because "one characteristic of the symbol is that it is never wholly arbitrary (1966: 68). A flag as a symbol for a country is often rooted in non-arbitrary criteria. Indeed, symbolism frequently emerges from indexicality and the non-arbitrary semiotic associations that define it.

Symbols are often described as *general* signs, which is true, but all types, all legisigns, are general signs; they are not coterminous with symbols, as both the iconicity of token/type recognition and the replica index make clear. Iconicity is general in that the objects represented are never specific instances. Since not all general signs stand for general objects in generally stipulated ways, not all general signs are symbols. Understanding the difference helps prevent symbolism from becoming a catchall label for every sign interpreted by habit. Generality is simply incomplete. The closest one can come to a definition of symbol centered on generality is that they are general signs for general objects, but this lacks both the precision and simplicity of defining symbols as signs assigned a rule of interpretation, signs stipulated as symbols. It is the stipulation that defines them, not the generality.

Convention is perhaps the most common defining characteristic for the symbol, even by Peirce (EP 2: 274),¹⁸ but this is equally insufficient. Turino (among others) criticizes convention as a defining characteristic of the symbol because there are conventional indices (Turino 2014). Convention can release indices from proximity with their objects (hence the point of identifying metonym indices), but this does not negate the causality or co-occurrence that links the sign with its object. Convention is rooted in habit and needn't be stipulated via language as law. Extending Deacon's argument that symbols are doubly conventional (Deacon 2012a: 11), I argue that convention is sufficient only if defined beyond the limits of typical English usage, rendering symbols triply conventional via the sign, the object, and the manner of representation. Each component must be stipulated and agreed upon. As Short says, "causal regularity does not equal convention" (Short 2007: 189). Overvaluing convention threatens to undermine the use value of semiotic theory in understanding music's non-symbolic meaning.

Finally, symbols require systems (Tomlinson 2018: 77). The systemic, syntactic, context of language (for instance) allows complexity, abstraction, and generality. Each symbol represented on this page relates to others in English, but the instance (the sinsign) is secondary. The pixels on your screen or the ink on the page have virtually nothing to do with how the letters combined into words combined into sentences and paragraphs mean anything as they are read. The word symbol (as a type) is what you, as the reader, interpret, not the multiple different instances on this page. If you do not understand my definition, it fails as a

18 While far from comprehensive, examples include anthropologists saying, "symbols involve convention" (Kohn 2013: 32), "Conventional relations between signs and objects that seem minimally motivated and maximally arbitrary" (Kockelman 2011: 717–718), and "relations based on arbitrary convention" (Parmentier 2016: 39); and musicologists with, "necessary convention" (Karbusicky 1987: 24), and "the sign which bears conventional meaning" (Lidov 1987: 73).

symbol. Music appears superficially to work similarly, as notes and attacks cohere into phrases and melodies. But the manner of interpretation and combination is quite different. This has proved a stumbling block for some music scholars who recognize the obvious systemic qualities of music and look for symbolic meaning therein. Symbolism emerges from and includes indexicality. As indices become conventional, agreed upon, assigned and general, they have the potential to become symbols, but it is not a given. While systematicity is foundational to symbolism (2018: 78), this does not mean the indices never operate systemically.

Tomlinson convincingly corrects the unnecessary restriction of systematicity to symbolism by explaining how indexical systematicity is actually a key component to musical meaning (Tomlinson 2015: 197–208). His explanations of indexical ordering and systematicity suggest that efforts to make symbolic cognition “the preeminent, definitive feature of humanness” (197) go too far, overlook non-symbolic behaviors, and treat the emergence of humanness too simplistically. As he says, “the missed opportunity looms large in the case of musicking” (2015: 197).

Symbols work because their objects are predetermined, predictable, arbitrary, general, systemic, and fixed. Mbira performance during ceremonies conventionally leads to ancestral spirits but it is not guaranteed. It must be interpreted as an actual connection, sign reacting to object. Tomlinson’s primary example of an indexical system is tonality, in which sounds have distanced themselves from semantic meaning over the course of human history but can now come together into “larger indexical units” that only make sense within the tonal systems in which they are embedded. They exhibit, “higher-level upstructuring with no symbolic outcome” (2015: 193). Turino describes differences between music and symbolic language in similar terms, although without reference to the archaeological record. Just as scholarship on language can *underestimate* the role of tone, gesture, prosody, or timbre in explanations of meaning, scholarship on music can *overestimate* the iconicity of the musical elements (such as tones, rhythms, and timbres) coming together into larger meaningful units like melodies to linguistic elements (like letters) coming together to form words and sentences. The levels of articulation are different (Turino n.d.). The ways in which letters shape words that shape sentences and paragraphs has few equivalents in music anywhere, let alone in Zimbabwe. Linguistic symbols are necessary and widespread, musical symbols are secondary and rare. Mbira playing conventionally leads to *vadzimu* possession but it is not guaranteed. It must be interpreted as an actual connection, sign reacting to object. The tonal regularities that allow “Shumba” to be interpreted as such are necessary for recognition, but have little direct bearing on possession.

In “Beyond the Symbolic Species,” Deacon demonstrates the hierarchical dependency of semiosis (symbols depend on indices depend on icons) with the example of a letter bearing the wax seal made from a signet ring to verify the sender’s identity. Briefly, the impression is similar to the ring, an icon; the act of pressing the ring into wax is caused by the individual wearing the ring, an index; and possession of the ring is a mark of authority granted via social convention (Deacon 2012a: 13). Working through the hierarchically nested sign types of iconicity leading to indexicality leading to symbolism, the wax seal becomes a symbol of social position. To understand the ring, one must understand these social conventions (and the systems of relations upon which they depend) because nothing intrinsic to the form or physical creation of the seal supplies this information. For Deacon, “without familiarity with this entire system of relationships, these non-symbolic components remain merely icons and indices” (2012a: 13).¹⁹

The salient sign here is the wax impression, a literal imprint of authority. Is social convention enough for the sign to operate symbolically? It is this specific ring (thus not a general object) that is indicated with the seal. The object is thus not general, as with symbols, but specific. The impression becomes metonymic of the authority bestowed by the ring, the specific authority embodied by the ring-bearer. The instance is essential in much the same way that immigration won’t accept a photocopy of my passport. Indexicality defines the meaning of the seal, both for the ring in literal proximity to the wearer and the impression as caused by this specific ring. That it is more than genuine deixis, operating as a “degenerate” replica index of the ring’s impression as a metonym of power, does not negate the role indexicality plays here. The object that leads to the sign is absent (ententional) but real and specific nonetheless. Symbols are ineffective in signifying specificity and authenticity because they work through agreement and generality. The ring might be a symbol of a certain authority (as stipulated by a rule of interpretation . . . likely through language), but the wax impression becomes an index of that symbol rather than a symbol itself. Symbols contextualize the impact of the wax impression’s indexical power, but the ring itself falls short of the symbolic.

What might this example offer a discussion of mbira playing? Hearers know quite a bit about the systems of relations that define the spirit world as well as the music performed for them. With respect, I’ve modified a lengthy quote from Deacon’s article to change the signs from seals to sounds and the objects from rings to spirits. My modification of Deacon reads,

19 As with many analyses of symbolism, recognition of icons and indices is often accompanied by diminishing qualifiers like “merely” that suggest that icons and indices are somehow qualitatively less than symbols.

Next consider the interpretation of the [song “Shumba”]. Initially, it appears just a [mbira piece], an iconic sinsign in Peircean terminology (a singular instance of something familiar). As similar [songs] are [heard during other ceremonies], it develops from an iconic sinsign to an iconic legisign (songs of the same type). As it is understood to distinguish the individual [hearing] it, it becomes interpreted as an indexical legisign (a type of sign vehicle pointing to something about this [ceremony or spirit]) . . . The same sign vehicle thus is the locus for a sequence of interpretive phases in which both the relationship of the sign vehicle to other sign vehicles and the relationship of the sign vehicle to its reference are progressively developed (Deacon 2012a: 14).

The ellipsis above omits an assertion by Deacon that this sign becomes a symbolic legisign; I stop short of interpreting mbira patterns in this way. They work as legisigns, certainly, but I question the presence of a “rule of interpretation.” The object is not stipulated but remains predicated on past experiences and purpose, iconicity to past indexicalities so to speak. The convention of using the mbira to invite spirits is not enough to ensure that a “rule of interpretation” is followed. The desired representation must be achieved experientially rather than stipulated symbolically. It must be felt as indexically connected by all involved, but especially the spirits, in order to trigger the semiotic processes necessary to result in possession. Neither the generality of the symbol’s sign nor its object is rooted in the here and now. The trance that enables possession and the visceral experiences of ceremonial action demand and depend on a heightened awareness of the here and now. Symbols can’t inspire ecstasy. They are meaningful, predictable, and flexible, but inert.²⁰

Despite my focus here on Oga’s mbira playing and the collective acknowledgment that mbira was essential, it was in many ways the *hosho* (rattles) upon which ceremonial success depended. It drove the beat home, viscerally, with consistent deictic references to now, now, now generating the haecceity that is at the heart of *communitas* and trance. Each requires focus and the *hosho* is what focuses attention. Its volume and insistence make listening a fully embodied act. The density, subtle precision, and textures rooted in the polyrhythms in the mbira and the *hosho*’s subtle anticipation of that important second pulse all pull people’s focus in such a way that, if done well, requires little thought or reflection. That is the importance of this indexical now. We collectively began with iconicity. It sounded like mbira music, Oga’s notes sounded like “Shumba.” Then the intentional foundation of degenerate indexicality grew in importance. Metonyms of the spirits – the mbira, snuff, etc. – drew on people’s memories, habits, and past experiences, raising the indexical *possibility* of the *vadzimu*, the ancestral spirits.

20 Similarly, for Turner, Levi-Strauss’s structuralism can “flatten” constituent elements, depriving them of dynamic or transformative capacities (Turner 2009: 5), a direct consequence of Saussurian thinking about signs.

The replica index of purpose, the intent to invite spirits and the expectations of possession further communicate to the spirits themselves and other participants the sincerity of the experience. But pure secondness and haecceity is the key. Iconicity and replication serve to help direct people to the here and now in the context of possession, generating the kinds of experiences by spirits, mediums, and musicians alike that ensure ceremonial success and spirit possession.

Symbolism may be the key to human difference, as Deacon argues (2012a: 9), but it doesn't influence a ceremonial experience as much as icons or indices. The predictability of symbolic thought removes the thinker from the proximity of the here and now. When Oga played, symbols were present, but experientially overshadowed by iconicity and the immediacy of indexicality. The conventions at the heart of this ceremony were tied to metonyms and replica indices, not symbols. Ceremonial engagement necessitates resistance to symbolic separation. Even if musical signs could be revealed as symbols through some sophisticated semiotic gymnastics, they still require specific instances and indexicality to matter experientially.

Identifying symbols as uniquely meaningful remains the desired endpoint for so much semiotic analysis in philosophy and anthropology that "symbol-ocentrism" carries on the linguocentric legacy semiotics could have otherwise avoided, as if the only meaningful mode of communication, expression, or representation is language and the symbols that dominate it. Samuels suggests that we "let go of our fetishization of meaning as the key to language and culture" (Samuels 2004: 318). He is concerned that the hope for "pure, transparent communication" might unnecessarily obscure and overwhelm the value of ambiguity and of nonsense. I share his concern, but also hope a more inclusive approach to meaning rooted in semiotics (with which Samuels is well-versed) might incorporate the ambiguous, the nonsensical, and the possible as much as the visceral and the actual. Extending meaning to the effects of signs, to interpretants, allows for that. One powerful benefit of an approach to meaning that acknowledges each component of the semiotic trifecta, accounting for signs themselves, the objects signified, the effects of those significations, and the purposes that shape interpretation, is a defense of the "merely" possible (implied in the ambiguity Samuels celebrates) as meaningful and influential in its own right. The dynamic intersection of semiotic possibilities, purposes, and signified realities becomes central to understanding ceremonial experience and the impact of shared musicking.

Kohn responds to the symbolocentric tendency by "provincializing language" (2013: 38). In doing so, he reduces symbols to signs of convention and leaves humanity behind. Language becomes justifiably limited, but less because it ignores other modes of signification (like music) than because it excludes nonhuman

beings (Descola 2016: 35). Kohn productively addresses meaning that doesn't depend on symbolic language, but *human* meaning remains implicitly reliant on the linguistic and the symbolic.²¹ Ethnomusicologists must continue to enter these conversations and show how music contributes to what it means to be meaningfully human. By addressing the unique combinatorial capacities of music and its obvious meanings, one can provincialize language without entirely provincializing humans, as valuable as that can be. Turino advocates prioritizing sign-object relations themselves (to follow the sign types) across modes of representation to avoid separating language from other representational modes a priori (Turino 2014). Symbolic value should not lead to the hopeful search for symbolism in all modes of human expression, communication, and experience. Iconicity can inspire the imagination and encourage creativity, symbolism allows for generality, description and abstraction, but the immediacy of affective experience in performance is stripped of all generality and mediation in favor of a sustained focus on the instance and haecceity, the here and now. Affective musical meaning *must* be indexical.

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²¹ Descola argues that Kohn's approach problematically limits agency to semiosis, and semiosis to organisms (Descola 2016: 36). While beyond the scope of this article, the relationship between agency and semiosis is complex. Biosemioticians would grant agency to anything selected (Kockelman 2017) or anything that "makes interpretants." I'm skeptical of the biosemiotic approach to agency (see also Short 2007; Tomlinson 2016), and would cautiously agree with Kohn that agency is productively limited to semiosis. There are other processes of thirdness that are not semiotic, but do have effects in the world (cell division, for instance).

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